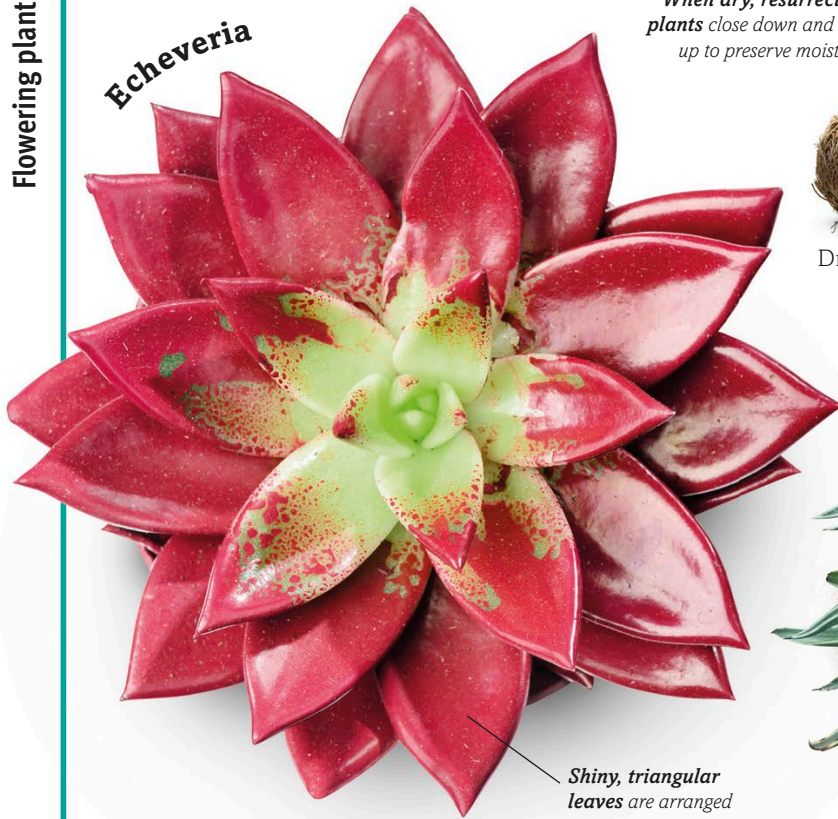




Desert survivors

Flowering plants

Echeveria



Shiny, triangular leaves are arranged in a rosette.

When dry, resurrection plants close down and curl up to preserve moisture.

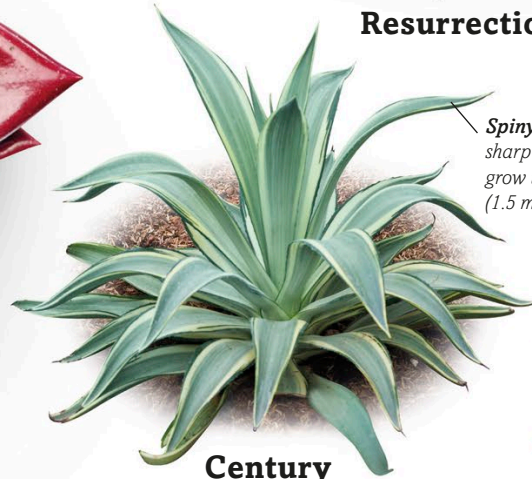


Dried plant

After rain, the leaves unfurl in a matter of hours.



Resurrection plant



Spiny leaves with sharp tips can grow up to 5 ft (1.5 m) in length.

Century plant

The high, thorny branches can be eaten only by giraffes, with their muscular tongues.



Camel thorn

The dense cushions of leaves of this poisonous plant trap water inside.



Llavea

A desert is a very dry area, with less than 10 in (25 cm) of rainfall a year. All plants need water to survive, but desert plants have adapted to their habitat by using ingenious methods of storing water, reducing the amount they lose, or just by being able to survive drying out.

The echeveria plant and the Queen Victoria agave retain water by trapping it inside their fleshy leaves. Their leaves also have a waxy surface that reflects the sun's rays and keeps the plant cool. The resurrection plant can lose more than 95 percent of its weight during dry periods, shriveling into a dry ball. It can survive